of Arab countries who refused to recognise the state of Israel and it was radical **Islamists** in the Egyptian army who assassinated Sadat in 1981.

The Islamic Revolution in Iran 1979

Key question
What was the impact of the Iranian Revolution in the Arab world?

What did surprise many people, in both the Muslim and the wider world, was that when the Islamic revolution first occurred, it was not in an Arab country but in Iran. The government of the Shah of Iran had seemed so strong with its large, modern army and a brutal secret police. Yet the Iranian Revolution was both revolutionary and Islamic (see Chapter 7). The Shah was overthrown by a massive, popular movement and a republic based on Islamic law, with a religious figure, Ayatollah Khomeini, as its 'supreme leader', was established (pages 118–20). Furthermore, Khomeini and his fellow religious leaders proclaimed that the governments of other Muslim countries in the Middle East were corrupt, un-Islamic and deserved to be overthrown. They particularly criticised those countries with ties to the West or to the Soviet Union.

Key dates
Islamic Revolution in Iran: 1979
Soviet invasion of Afghanistan: 1979

Although many millions of Arab Muslims applauded the Islamic Revolution in Iran, especially when the Iranians defied the USA by taking its diplomats hostage, their enthusiasm soon waned while the governments of most Arab states became highly suspicious of Iran. This was partly for historical reasons: Iran was Persian, not Arab. It was also partly for religious reasons: the people of Iran were mostly Shiite Muslims whereas the Arab Muslims were mostly Sunnis. When Iran found itself at war with Iraq in 1980, most Arab, Muslim states supported secular, Sunni-dominated, Arab Iraq (page 122).

Key terms
Islamists
Those who believe in political Islam.

Mujahideen
An Arabic word meaning 'those who struggle', for example in a *jihad*, or holy war.

Most Arab states did not want to embrace radical Islamic politics. For those Arabs who *did* want to see the spread of political Islam, it was Afghanistan (see map on page 116), to the east of Iran, that provided the focus for their energies after 1979.

The emergence of al-Qaida

Key question
Where and how did al-Qaida emerge?

In 1978, Afghan communists, supported by the Soviet Union, seized control of the government of their country. They immediately faced rebellion from a number of Islamist groups who resented the foreign, communist influence of their pro-Soviet government. In December 1979 the Soviet Union sent in troops to assist the government. This invasion led to a huge rebellion and, over the next 10 years, the Afghan guerrillas, or ***mujahideen***, were to fight the Soviet troops. The *mujahideen* were seen as patriots fighting for Afghan independence and they received massive support. Not only did Muslim countries like Saudi Arabia and neighbouring Pakistan (a Muslim country) provide support, but so too did the USA, Britain and other Western countries because they wanted to push back the Soviet forces and defeat the USSR. This was still the era of the Cold War and the West was keen to resist the advance of what the US President, Ronald Reagan, called the 'evil empire'.